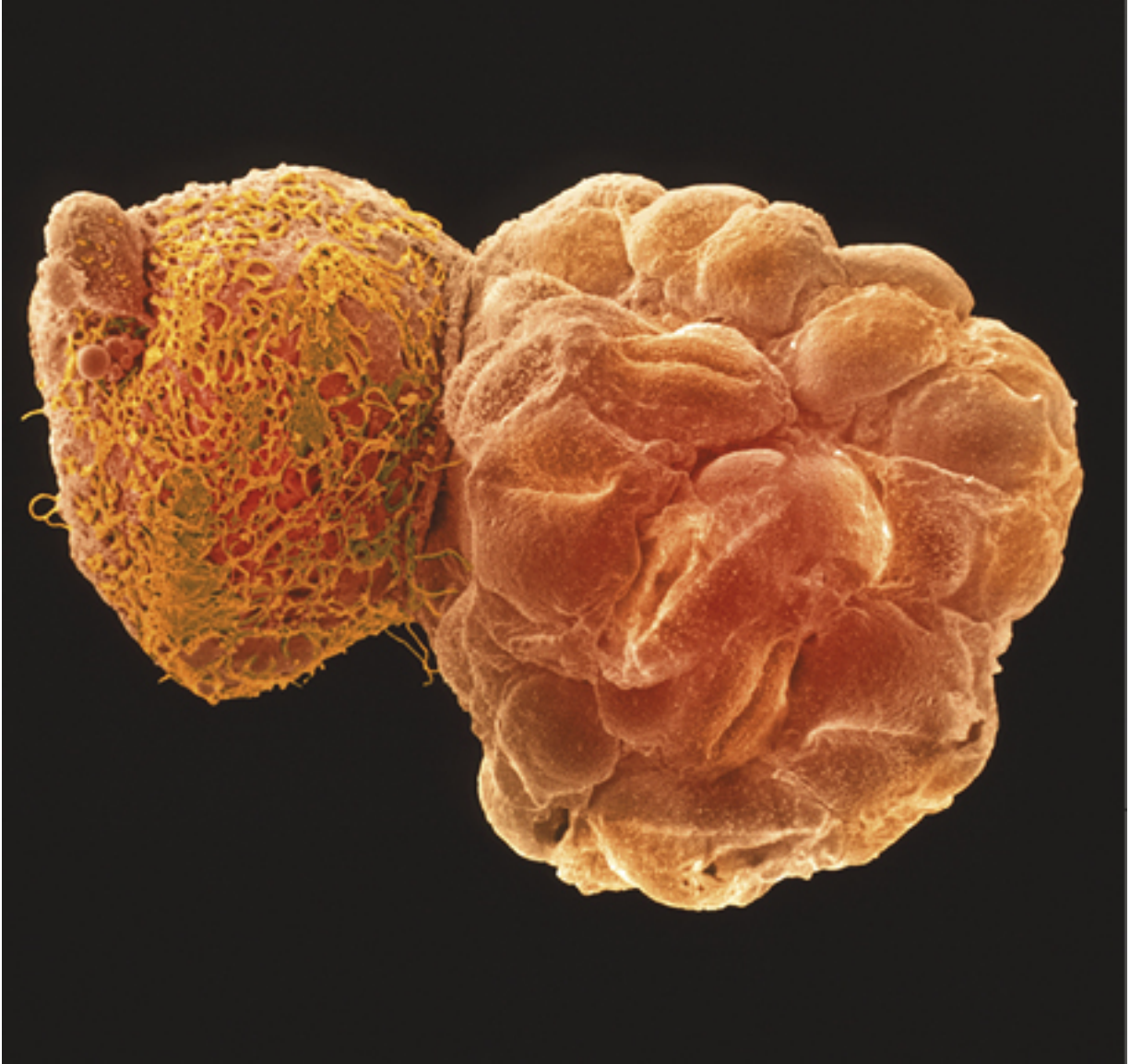




A **blastocyst**, a mass of up to 100 cells, hatches out of the egg's protective layer and prepares to implant in the uterus.

The journey of the sperm

During sex, the man releases an abundance of sperm—around 250 million at each ejaculation—into the vagina. Each sperm has a long tail to propel it, so it's well equipped to swim up to the fallopian tube, where fertilization of the egg takes place. The whole distance, from the vagina through the uterus and up into the fallopian tube can be accomplished in hours. However, the sperm can survive in the vagina and the uterus for three to five days, meaning there is a window of around six days in which fertilization can take place (an egg lives 12–24 hours after ovulation). Not all of the millions of sperm make it as far as the fallopian tube; in fact, most of them die, seep out of the vagina, or get lost along the way. Around just 200 sperm, only a tiny fraction of the number originally released, arrive at the site of the egg.